

A ONE-DECISION GUIDE

Pick Your Grays

How to choose one dark background, build a full gray scale from it, and flip it into light mode. Six rules. One worksheet.

1 • PICK THE DARK BACKGROUND

2 • BUILD THE SCALE

3 • GIVE EACH STEP A JOB

4 • FLIP TO LIGHT



Why dark first? Dark mode is harder. If your grays work on dark, light mode is a mirror. If you start light, dark mode is a redo.

Pick your dark background

Everything else comes from this one color. Spend your time here.

Rule 1 • It is not black

Pure `#000000` makes everything on top of it look like it's floating. Use a very dark gray: **lightness 3% to 8%**.

Rule 2 • It has a hint of your brand hue

Take the hue (H) from your brand color. Keep it. Drop saturation (S) to **3% to 10%**. Above about 12% it stops reading as gray. If you can name the color at a glance, it's too much.

YOUR BRAND IS...	TINT THE GRAY...	TAILWIND NAME	DARK BACKGROUND
Blue, indigo, violet, sky	Cool (toward blue)	<code>slate</code>	<code>#020617</code> · H222 S47 L5
Red, pink, black, none	Almost neutral (tiny bit blue)	<code>zinc</code>	<code>#09090b</code> · H240 S10 L4
Green, teal, orange, amber, brown	Warm (toward yellow)	<code>stone</code>	<code>#0c0a09</code> · H20 S14 L4

The three safe picks

slate · cool

Card on slate
 Secondary text

zinc · neutral

Card on zinc
 Secondary text

stone · warm

Card on stone
 Secondary text

Rule 3 • Pure white is not your text either

White on dark glows and tires the eyes. Use the lightest step of your scale (about 98% lightness, like `#fafafa`).

Write it down

My dark background: _____ Hue: _____ Sat: _____ % Light: _____ %

Beginner shortcut: pick zinc, slate, or stone from the table. They already follow every rule in this guide. Build your own on project three.

Eleven steps from one color

Keep the hue. Keep the saturation. Only change lightness. Use this ladder.

STEP	950	900	800	700	600	500	400	300	200	100	50
Lightness %	5	10	16	25	33	46	64	83	90	96	98

Notice the steps are **not even**. They bunch up at the light end (98, 96, 90) because the eye can tell light grays apart and you need many for backgrounds and borders. They spread out in the middle where you need fewer.

Example: zinc, built from #09090b

950 #09090b	900 #18181b	800 #27272a	700 #3f3f46	600 #52525b	500 #71717a	400 #a1a1aa	300 #d4d4d8	200 #e4e4e7	100 #f4f4f5	50 #fafafa

Example: slate, built from #020617

950 #020617	900 #0f172a	800 #1e293b	700 #334155	600 #475569	500 #64748b	400 #94a3b8	300 #cbd5e1	200 #e2e8f0	100 #f1f5f9	50 #f8fafc

Example: stone, built from #0c0a09

950 #0c0a09	900 #1c1917	800 #292524	700 #44403c	600 #57534e	500 #78716c	400 #a8a29e	300 #d6d3d1	200 #e7e5e4	100 #f5f5f4	50 #fafaf9

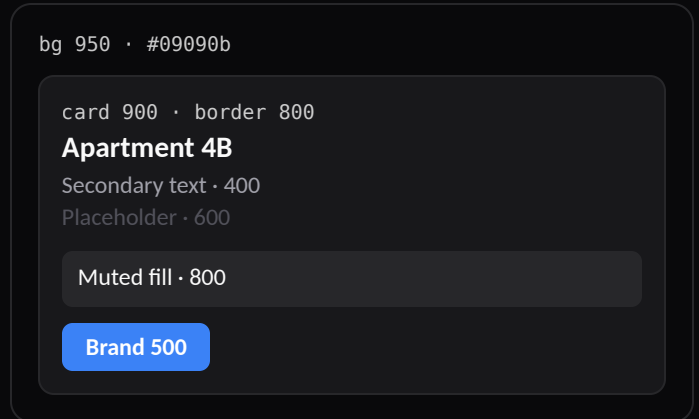
Rule 4 • The neighbor test

Put all 11 in a row. Every step should look a little different from the one next to it. Two look the same? One is wrong. One jumps too far? Add 2–3 points of saturation to the dark steps so they don't go muddy.

Dark mode uses six of the eleven

Don't use all of them. Each one gets one job. Lighter means closer to the viewer.

JOB	STEP	WHY
Page background	950	The base. Not black.
Card, panel, dialog	900	One step lighter = "on top." Shadows don't show on dark, so this is depth.
Muted fill, hover, input	800	Two steps up.
Border, divider	800	Same as muted. Just visible.
Disabled, placeholder	600	Readable but clearly "off."
Secondary text	400	Passes 4.5:1 on 950. 500 does not.
Main text, headings	50	Your "white."



Skipped: 700, 500, 300, 200, 100. They're for light mode.

Rule 5 • Brand color on dark

- Use the **500** step of your brand color on dark (you'll use 600 on light). Lighter pops more on black.
- Pull saturation back 10–20%. Bright colors on dark look neon.
- Text on the brand button is still white, or your 50 step.

Rule 6 • Check contrast (six pairs)

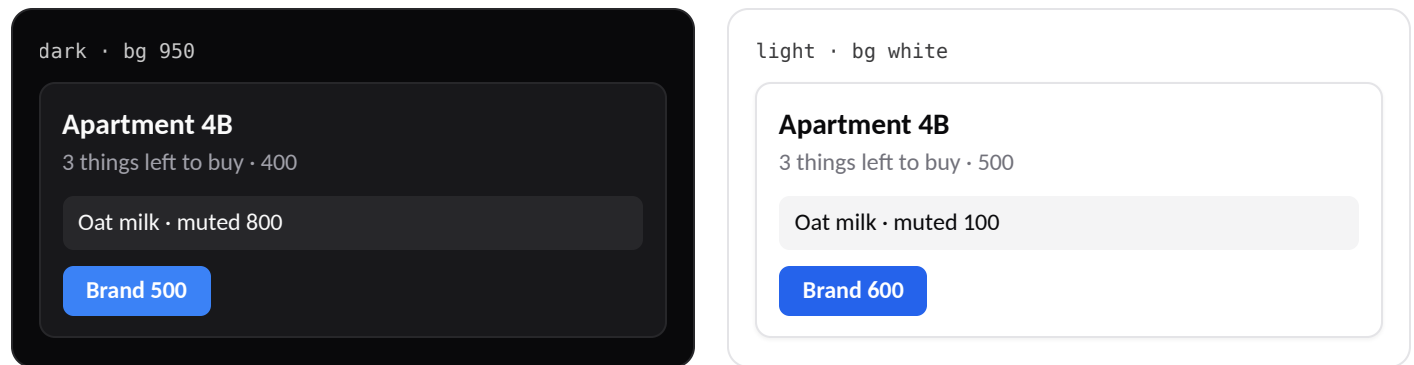
PAIR	NEED	ZINC RESULT
Main text (50) on page (950)	4.5 : 1	19 : 1 ✓
Main text (50) on card (900)	4.5 : 1	16 : 1 ✓
Secondary text (400) on page (950)	4.5 : 1	7.5 : 1 ✓
Secondary text (400) on card (900)	4.5 : 1	6.4 : 1 ✓
Border (800) on page (950)	1.5 : 1 (decorative)	1.6 : 1 ✓
White on brand (500)	4.5 : 1	Check yours. Blue-500 is 3.7 — use 600 for text-heavy buttons.

Light mode is a mirror of the jobs, not the colors

Don't invert the hex values. Keep the same jobs and re-assign steps from the other end of the scale.

JOB	DARK	LIGHT	NOTE
Page background	950	white	Pure white is fine for the page.
Card, panel, dialog	900	white	Same as page. Depth comes from border + shadow instead.
Muted fill, hover, input	800	100	One step off white.
Border, divider	800	200	Two steps off white.
Disabled, placeholder	600	400	
Secondary text	400	500	500 passes 4.5:1 on white. 400 fails.
Main text, headings	50	950	Your "black." Not #000.
Brand color	500	600	Darker on light so white text passes.
Shadows	none	shadow-sm	Shadows only work on light.

Same card, both modes



The three light-mode mistakes

Using 400 for helper text (fails contrast). Using pure #000 for body text (too harsh). Making the card darker than the page (backwards; on light, cards are white with a border).

Six more contrast checks

Main text (950) on white: 19:1 ✓ · Secondary (500) on white: 4.8:1 ✓ · Secondary (500) on muted (100): 4.4:1 — borderline, use 600 inside muted fills · Border (200) on white: 1.3:1, fine for lines · White on brand (600): check yours; blue-600 is 5.2:1 ✓

How popular apps do it

Same six jobs, every time. Values sampled from their public design systems and UI; close, not exact.

Dark mode

	PAGE	CARD	BORDER	2ND TEXT	TEXT
Vercel / Geist neutral, near-black	#0a0a0a	#1a1a1a	#2e2e2e	#a1a1a1	#ededed
GitHub / Primer cool, blue-tinted	#0d1117	#161b22	#30363d	#8b949e	#e6edf3
Discord cool, lifted (not near-black)	#313338	#2b2d31	#1e1f22	#949ba4	#dbdee1
Notion neutral, soft	#191919	#202020	#2f2f2f	#9b9b9b	#d4d4d4
Apple iOS true black + gray layers	#000000	#1c1c1e	#38383a	#8e8e93	#ffffff
Material 3 warm-violet tint	#141218	#211f26	#49454f	#cac4d0	#e6e0e9

Light mode (same apps)

	PAGE	MUTED	BORDER	2ND TEXT	TEXT
Vercel / Geist	#ffffff	#fafafa	#eaeaea	#666666	#171717
GitHub / Primer	#ffffff	#f6f8fa	#d0d7de	#57606a	#24292f
Notion	#ffffff	#f7f7f5	#e9e9e7	#787774	#37352f
Apple iOS	#ffffff	#f2f2f7	#c6c6c8	#8e8e93	#000000

What to notice

Nobody uses pure mid-gray. GitHub leans blue. Material leans violet. Notion leans warm. Discord skips near-black and lifts the whole page to #313338 so it feels softer. Apple is the one that uses true #000, and it pays for it with three gray layers on top.

Fill this in, then you're done

Twenty minutes. Do it once per project.

- 1 My brand color: _____ so my gray tint is: ☐ cool (slate) ☐ neutral (zinc) ☐ warm (stone) ☐ custom
- 2 My dark background (950): _____ H _____ S _____ % L _____ % (L between 3 and 8, S between 3 and 10)
- 3 My scale (same H and S, lightness from the ladder):

950	900	800	700	600	500	400	300	200	100	50
L 5	L 10	L 16	L 25	L 33	L 46	L 64	L 83	L 90	L 96	L 98
#	#	#	#	#	#	#	#	#	#	#

- 4 Neighbor test passed (all 11 look different, no big jumps): ☐

- 5 Jobs assigned:

JOB	DARK STEP	DARK HEX	LIGHT STEP	LIGHT HEX
Page background	950	#	white	ffffff
Card	900	#	white	ffffff
Muted fill / hover	800	#	100	#
Border	800	#	200	#
Disabled / placeholder	600	#	400	#
Secondary text	400	#	500	#
Main text	50	#	950	#
Brand	500	#	600	#

- 6 Contrast checked, both modes (12 pairs, all at or above 4.5:1 for text): ☐

- 7 Pasted into `globals.css` under `:root` (light) and `.dark` (dark): ☐

The six rules, one line each

1. Background is dark gray, not black. 2. Tint it toward your brand hue, 3–10% saturation. 3. Text is the 50 step, not white. 4. Build 11 steps by changing only lightness; pass the neighbor test. 5. Brand is 500 on dark, 600 on light. 6. Light mode mirrors the jobs, not the hex values.

Free contrast checker: search "WebAIM contrast checker." Paste two hex values, read the number.